Module 2 · Workbook answers

Visualisation and Imagination

Video: 41 min **Answer sheet**

Module 1 gave the foundation: Allah is with you, hears you and sees you. This module builds on it with the first half of the hadith on ihsan (excellence in worship), "worship Allah as if you see Him", and shows how to take control of your imagination so that it brings you closer to Allah instead of drifting to the shopping list.

Answer sheet: the answers are in red. The reflection questions are personal, so your own answers will be in your own words and from your own life. These model answers show what the session teaches, to guide and check your thinking.

Key teachings

1. **Revision: the foundation of presence**

   The opposite of huḍūr (presence with Allah) is being ghafil (heedless) and distracted, as most of us are in prayer, with the children, work and a hundred other things. Presence is the string that holds the beads of our worship together; if it snaps, everything falls. Last time we built the three keys from Surah Ta-Ha 20:46: Allah is seeing me (the police car, the security camera, the stadium screen), Allah is hearing me (even my whispers and thoughts, free of charge, and He never misunderstands), and Allah is with me (the dua of light, and the body He runs for us, down to the bridge-shaped bones of the feet).

2. **Building on the foundation: "as if you see Him"**

   The foundation is compulsory, like the foundation of a building; once it is in place you can enhance it, as you would decorate the inside. Module 1 used the second half of the hadith of Jibril: if you do not see Allah, know that He sees you. This module uses the first half: worship Allah as if you see Him. That is what is meant by visualisation. It may sound unusual, but it is firmly rooted in our tradition.

3. **The simplest start: the name of Allah**

   Anyone can begin by visualising the name of Allah, the sign that points purely to Him. Look at how every letter points to Him: take away the alif and you have lillāh (for Allah); take away the next lam and you have lahu (for Him); take away the last lam and you have Hu (He). Think how a photo of your mother feeding you or putting you to sleep, or of your father going out to work to provide for you, stirs love and longing. If a picture of your parents can do that, what about your Creator, who made your body, mind, heart, ego and spirit?

4. **The Companions saw with their hearts**

   Haritha told the Prophet ﷺ he had woken up a true believer: it was as if he could see the Throne of his Lord, the people of Paradise visiting one another and the people of the Fire crying out; the Prophet ﷺ said, "You have understood, so hold fast to it." Hanzala feared he had become a hypocrite because he saw Paradise and the Fire as if with his own eyes in the Prophet's company, but forgot at home; Abu Bakr said the same happened to him. Umar called out "O Sariya, the mountain!" in the middle of a khutbah, and the army far away heard him and was saved from an ambush. The Prophet ﷺ himself was shown Paradise and the Fire in prayer, close enough almost to take a bunch of grapes.

5 **Start where you are: three levels**

These stories can feel far away when we can barely remember which rak'ah we are in, and many people lose the vividness they had when they first started practising. So be realistic and start where you are. Level 1 is thought: simply thinking about Allah, with no picture, which you can control. Level 2 is a visual image you deliberately create, which you can also control. Level 3 is the spiritual level, like the experiences of the Companions, which is not in your control. It is fine that at first you are creating the image yourself; that is the point.

6 **The power of imagination, and places to use it**

Imagination comes from the Latin for forming a picture in your mind. A horror film is completely made up, yet your body is genuinely scared; visualisation for Allah does the opposite. Choose a scene: alone on a raft in the middle of the ocean with no one coming to save you, just you and Allah (the speaker's favourite); praying in front of the Ka'bah again; a forest, with its sounds and greenery; Madinah, whose beauty (Makkah has majesty) comes from the Prophet ﷺ; the desert or the cave of the Hijrah; Masjid al-Aqsa, where the Prophet ﷺ led the prophets; or a mountain. You are probably visualising already, just Asda, Tesco and your DIY list. This is about taking control of your imagination, and it does not need to be more complicated than that.

7 **The guided light visualisation**

Look at the name of Allah and trace it with your eyes until it leaves an imprint. Close your eyes and picture it above your head, lighting the whole sky, then shining down on you: your head, shoulders, body and legs, until you are full of light. Just you and the name of Allah; nothing else matters. Bring in the three keys: Allah sees the effort you are making to get close to Him; send every anxiety ("Is this working? Am I getting it right?") to Him from your heart; and He is with you, beating your heart, running your breathing, blinking, immune system and hormones.

8 **When the mind races, and the honour of being His servant**

A racing mind is very common. You cannot empty your mind, so fill it with Allah; we are visual people, so give the mind something to look at. The speaker admits he overcomplicates things, so he brings himself back and says, "Allah will take care of it." Remember that once you did not exist at all (76:1); simply existing is overwhelming. Allah calls the Prophet ﷺ His servant (17:1), and the Prophet ﷺ chose to be a servant-prophet rather than a king-prophet. Humility before Allah is rare, and like gold compared with water, what is rare is precious. Next module: communicating with Allah through the heart.

From the Qur'an, the Sunnah and the scholars

> *Ihsan is that you worship Allah as though you see Him, and if you do not see Him, then indeed He sees you.*
>
> **Hadith of Jibril, Sahih Muslim and Sahih al-Bukhari**

> *Haritha said: "It is as if I see the Throne of my Lord clearly, as if I see the people of Paradise visiting one another, and as if I see the people of the Fire crying out in it." The Prophet ﷺ said: "O Haritha, you have understood, so hold fast to it."*
>
> **Narrated by al-Tabarani**

> *By Him in whose hand is my life, if you remained as you are in my presence and in remembrance, the angels would shake hands with you on your beds and in your paths. But, O Hanzala, there is a time for this and a time for that.*
>
> **Sahih Muslim**

يَٰٓأَيُّهَا ٱلْإِنسَٰنُ مَا غَرَّكَ بِرَبِّكَ ٱلْكَرِيمِ ﴿٦﴾ ٱلَّذِى خَلَقَكَ فَسَوَّىٰكَ فَعَدَلَكَ

O mankind, what has deceived you concerning your Lord, the Generous, Who created you, proportioned you, and balanced you?

Surah al-Infitar 82:6–7

هَلْ أَتَىٰ عَلَى ٱلْإِنسَٰنِ حِينٌ مِّنَ ٱلدَّهْرِ لَمْ يَكُن شَيْـًٔا مَّذْكُورًا

Has there [not] come upon man a period of time when he was not a thing [even] mentioned?

Surah al-Insan 76:1

> *It is honour enough for me to have a Lord, and pride enough for me to be His servant.*
>
> **A poet, quoted in the session**

Practical exercises

The name of Allah, and the photo of your parents

1. Picture your mother caring for you as a baby, or your father going out to work for you. Notice what you feel.
2. Now look at the name of Allah and trace each letter with your eyes: Allah, lillāh, lahu, Hu.
3. Close your eyes and hold the name in your mind for a minute.
4. Remind yourself: this is my Creator, who made my body, mind, heart and spirit.
5. Write what you felt, and how it compared with the photo of your parents.

Choose your place of presence

1. Try each scene for a minute with your eyes closed: the raft in the ocean, the Ka'bah, a forest, Madinah, the cave of the Hijrah, Masjid al-Aqsa, a mountain.
2. Add the details: the sounds, the light, the air, the feeling of being alone with Allah.
3. Notice which scene makes you feel most present with Allah.
4. Bring that scene to mind in the moments before your next salah.
5. Write down your chosen scene and what happened in the prayer.

The guided light visualisation

1. Look at the name of Allah for about ten seconds and trace it with your eyes until it leaves an imprint.
2. Close your eyes. Picture the name above your head, lighting up the whole sky.
3. Let the light shine down onto your head, shoulders, body and legs until you are full of light.
4. Bring in the three keys: Allah sees your effort, hears what is in your heart, and is with you, beating your heart.
5. Send each worry or doubt that comes up to Allah, then return to the name and the light.
6. Afterwards, write how it went: did it work, did you struggle, did your mind race?

7-day practice: visualisation and imagination

Tick each day you practise.

	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
Visualised the name of Allah							
Light visualisation before a prayer							
Used my chosen scene in salah							
Brought my mind back to Allah							

Reflection questions and answers

1. What do you usually find yourself visualising in salah? What does that show you about where your imagination goes?

> The session points out that most of us are already visualising in prayer, just Asda, Tesco and the DIY list. This shows that imagination is powerful and always working; the aim is not to switch it off but to take control of it and direct it towards Allah. For example: I usually picture my work to-do list, which shows my imagination goes wherever my worries are.

2. How did picturing your mother or father make you feel, and what would it mean to feel that towards your Creator?

> A photo of your mother feeding you or putting you to sleep, or of your father going out to work for you, stirs love and longing. If a picture of your parents can do that, how much more should your Creator, who made your body, mind, heart, ego and spirit? For example: picturing my mother made me feel warm and grateful; feeling that towards Allah would turn my prayer from a duty into time with the One who has cared for me all along.

3. Which story moved you most: Haritha, Hanzala, Umar or the Prophet ﷺ seeing Paradise in prayer? Why?

> The session gives four examples of seeing with the heart: Haritha, who felt as if he could see the Throne, Paradise and the Fire and was told to hold fast; Hanzala, who feared hypocrisy because the feeling faded at home; Umar calling "O Sariya, the mountain!" during a khutbah; and the Prophet ﷺ being shown Paradise and the Fire in prayer. For example: Hanzala moved me most, because I too feel close to Allah at a gathering and forget at home, and it comforts me that Abu Bakr said the same.

4. Which of the three levels (thought, visual image, spiritual) are you at now, and what would help you move up a level?

> The three levels are: Level 1, thought (simply thinking about Allah, with no picture); Level 2, a visual image you deliberately create; and Level 3, the spiritual level, like the experiences of the Companions, which is not in your control. The first two are in your control, and it is fine to create the image yourself at first. For example: I am at Level 1, and practising the name of Allah visualisation daily could help me move to Level 2.

5. Which scene brought you closest to Allah, and why do you think it works for you?

> The scenes offered include the raft alone in the middle of the ocean (the speaker's favourite), praying before the Ka'bah, a forest, Madinah with its beauty, the desert or the cave of the Hijrah, Masjid al-Aqsa and a mountain. The best scene is the one that makes you feel most alone with Allah and most present. For example: the raft worked best for me, because with no one coming to save me I felt that only Allah could help.

6. When your mind races, what thoughts come most often, and how could you hand them to Allah instead?

> A racing mind is very common, and you cannot empty it, so fill it with Allah and give it something to look at, such as the name of Allah filled with light. Send every anxiety, even "Is this working?", to Him from your heart, and like the speaker, bring yourself back with "Allah will take care of it." For example: my mind races with work deadlines; I could tell Allah about each one and then return to the light.

7. What does being Allah's servant mean to you, and how could you show that humility in your next prayer?

> Allah calls the Prophet ﷺ His servant, and he chose to be a servant-prophet rather than a king-prophet. Humility before Allah is rare, and like gold compared with water, what is rare is precious; as the poet said, it is honour enough to have a Lord and pride enough to be His servant. For example: in my next prayer I could stay a little longer in prostration and remember that once I did not exist at all, so simply being here is His gift.

My action plan

- [ ] I will visualise the name of Allah for a few minutes each day this week.
- [ ] I will do the light visualisation before at least one prayer each day.
- [ ] I will choose one scene of presence and bring it to mind before I pray.
- [ ] When my mind races, I will fill it with Allah and say, "Allah will take care of it."
- [ ] I will share honest feedback with the group on what worked and what I struggled with.
- [ ] I will come to the next module ready to learn to communicate with Allah through my heart.